Financial Literacy through games

- *Cash Course: Your First Paycheck*

SCREEN 0: The Disclaimer & Title

- **Visual:** Plain, serious font on a dark background.
- **Text:** "WE DO NOT ENDORSE GAMBLING. By continuing you acknowledge that this website is not responsible for any future gambling."
- **Action:** Player clicks "I Acknowledge."
- **Transition:** Screen fades into a vibrant, arcade-style title screen.
- **Title Idea:** *Fortune's Path* or *Cash Course: Leo's First Paycheck*.
- **Action:** Player clicks **[START!]**

SCREEN 1: The Inciting Incident (The Crossroads)

- **Visual:** Leo is standing in his bedroom holding a thick envelope of cash ($500). Speech bubbles show his thoughts: a new gaming laptop, saving for a car, or just going out with friends.
- **Text:** "Meet Leo. He just finished his first week barista-ing and has $500 in cold, hard cash. Keeping it under his mattress feels risky, and he wants to buy a laptop eventually. What should he do first?"
- **Choices:**
  - **A:** Go to the local bank to open a standard checking account. *(Path 1: The Debit Card)*
  - **B:** Look into getting a credit card to buy the laptop immediately. *(Path 2: The Credit Card)*
  - **C:** Walk past the local convenience store and see a sign for a massive $10 Million Lottery. *(Path 3: The Gambling Trap)*
  - **D:** Talk to his older sister, an economics student, about how to grow his money. *(Path 4: The Investment Route)*
  - **E:** *[New Idea]* Buy the laptop right now from a sketchy online seller offering "No Money Down, Pay Later!" *(Path 5: The "Buy Now, Pay Later" Trap)*

PATH 1: The Debit Card (Learning Modern Banking)

- **Scene 1:** Leo sits across from a friendly bank teller.
- **Choice:** The teller asks, "Do you want a Savings account, a Checking account, or both?"
- **Lesson:** The game explains that Checking is for daily spending (Debit Card) and Savings is for keeping money safe. Leo chooses both and splits his money ($400 in Checking, $100 in Savings).
- **Scene 2:** Leo goes to a store and taps his new Debit card to buy groceries.
- **Game Mechanism:** The UI shows his balance instantly drop from $400 to $350.

- **The Takeaway:** "A debit card is your *own* money. When it hits $0, the card stops working. It prevents debt, but it doesn't build credit."

PATH 2: The Credit Card (Learning Credit Scores & Debt)

- **Scene 1:** Leo goes online to apply for a credit card so he can buy a $600 laptop today, even though he only has $500.
- **Choice:** He is offered a "Student Secured Credit Card" with a $300 limit, or a sketchy "Premium Card" with a $1,000 limit but a 29% APR interest rate. Leo chooses the Premium Card to get the laptop.
- **Scene 2:** One month later. Leo gets a bill. He can't pay the full balance, so he chooses the option: **[Pay Minimum Balance: $25]**.
- **The Twist:** A time-skip animation shows Leo 6 months later. He has paid $150 total, but because of high interest (APR), he still owes $550! He is trapped in debt.
- **The Takeaway:** "Credit cards are *borrowed* money. If you don't pay it back in full every month, you pay massive penalties. Only spend what you can afford to pay off immediately."

PATH 3: The Gambling Trap (The Illusion of Easy Money)

- **Scene 1:** Leo walks into the convenience store. The clerk says, "The jackpot is at $10 Million! Tickets are only $10."
- **Choice:** Leo decides to test his luck. **[Buy 1 ticket for $10]** or **[Go all in: Buy 50 tickets for $500]**.
- **The Mechanic:** A slot-machine or wheel-spin mini-game animation plays.
  - *Code-wise, give the player a 99% chance to lose everything, and a 1% chance to win a tiny amount ($20).*
- **Scenario A (99% chance):** The screen says "LOSER." Leo's balance drops to $0. He is staring at a trash can full of worthless paper. He can't afford gas or food.
- **Scenario B (1% chance - The Psychological Trap):** Leo wins $20! He feels a rush of dopamine. The game prompts him: "Wow! You doubled your money! Spin again?" If he spins again, he loses it all.
- **The Takeaway:** "The house always wins. Gambling is designed to exploit human psychology. It is entertainment, *never* a financial strategy."

PATH 4: The Investment Route (Learning Compound Interest)

- **Scene 1:** Leo's sister explains the stock market and index funds. She tells him about "Compound Interest."
- **Choice:** Leo can invest his $500 into a safe, diversified Index Fund, or put it all into a trendy "Meme Cryptocurrency" his friend told him about.
- **Scenario A (Index Fund):** A time-lapse fast-forwards 10 years. We see Leo's money steadily grow through compound interest without him doing anything.

- **Scenario B (Meme Crypto):** The crypto spikes up, Leo feels rich, then it crashes to $0 overnight.
- **The Takeaway:** "Investing is putting your money to work in real businesses. True investing takes time and patience; hype-based trading is just gambling in disguise."

3 More Branching Ideas to Expand the Game

To make the game even more robust, here are three additional financial literacy paths you can add:

Idea 5: The "Buy Now, Pay Later" (BNPL) & Subscription Trap

- **The Story:** Leo wants to buy clothes online. The checkout screen says: "Only 4 easy payments of $25!" It sounds so cheap. He signs up for three different BNPL plans and forgets about them.
- **The Crisis:** Next month, all the automatic payments hit his account at the same time, overdrafting his bank account and hitting him with hidden bank fees.
- **Lesson:** Hidden fixed costs and micro-transactions eat away at your wealth without you realizing it.

Idea 6: The Emergency Fund (Handling Unexpected Events)

- **The Story:** Leo is doing great. He chose a good path and saved $500. Suddenly, a pop-up appears: *CRASH!* Leo drops his smartphone and shatters the screen. It costs $300 to fix.
- **Choice:** If Leo put his money in an "Emergency Fund," he pays it easily and is stressed but fine. If Leo spent all his money on clothes/video games, he now has to beg his parents for a loan or skip social events for a month.
- **Lesson:** Life is unpredictable. An emergency fund is your financial shield.

Idea 7: The "Needs vs. Wants" Budgeting Challenge

- **The Story:** Leo goes to the grocery store with $100. The screen shows a shopping cart.
- **The Gameplay:** Items pass by on a conveyor belt. Leo must sort them into "Needs" (Eggs, Vegetables, Rent payment, Bus pass) and "Wants" (Designer shoes, Energy drinks, Video game skins).
- **The Outcome:** If he fills his cart with Wants, he runs out of money before buying dinner.
- **Lesson:** Budgeting isn't about starving yourself; it's about prioritizing your *needs* so you have room to safely enjoy your *wants*.

How the Game Ends:

At the end of any path, show a **"Financial Report Card."** * Give Leo a Net Worth score, a Credit Score, and a Happiness Score.

- If he gambled or went into credit card debt, show a "Game Over: Leo is broke and stressed."
- Include a button that says: **[Rewind Time & Try a Better Path!]** to encourage replayability and learning.